

SHOME BASU



Driving a Change

DELHI The Delhi Government plans to give more rights to mothers. And the gender-just mandate comes from the most unlikely of departments—the Transport Ministry. In response to a representation made by the Social Communication Centre (SCC) under the advocacy of Creative Thinkers' Forum, the ministry has decided to loosen up the Central Motor Vehicles Rules. By an order dated March 25, driving licence applicants will now have

the option of mentioning their mother's instead of their father's name, even for a learner's licence.

Under the influence of the Hindu Minority and Guardianship Act of 1956, the nation still favours the father as the "natural guardian" (although, the same laws prefer the mother in custody battles). But times are changing. The crucial dent to this antiquated law came about in 1999, when the Supreme Court held (*Gita Hariharan versus Reserve*

TOP GEAR: Licence forms will have mother's name

Bank of India) both parents as equal guardians under the Act. In 2006, the apex court also declared that a divorced mother can be granted custody of her minor child even if she remarries.

Educational institutes, the first to limber up, have pitched in for mothers' rights in right earnest. Last year, CBSE allowed candidates the option of mentioning the mother's name on board records.

But the more things change, the more they remain the same. Most public documents—PAN cards to property deeds—still ask for authorisation from the father. "Lack of awareness among government officials is the biggest stumbling block," says Vijay Sanghvi, secretary, SCC and the man who got the Transport Ministry to amend its rules through relentless petitioning since last year. The next project? A storm of campaigning for women's right to own ration cards as mater familias.

by Damayanti Datta

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Kamalesh Sharma, 66, India's former high commissioner in London, as the new secretary-general of the 53-member Commonwealth Nations. He will be the first Indian to hold the post.



RESIGNED: Orissa Speaker Maheshwar Mohanty following charges of

sexual harassment from a lady assistant marshal of the Assembly.

APPOINTED: Navtej Sarna as India's envoy to Israel. The 1980-batch IFS officer will succeed Arun Singh. Sarna is joint secretary in the MEA and is the longest-serving spokesman of the Foreign Office.

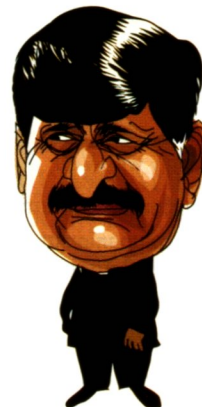
SENTENCED: By a Delhi court, former Congress leader and alleged Dawood Ibrahim aide Romesh Sharma to two years' imprisonment for non-payment of Rs 4 crore in income tax.

VIS-A-VIS MULAYAM SINGH YADAV Samajwadi Party president versus RAVI SHANKAR PRASAD BJP spokesperson

The Congress is not our enemy. But we have no plans of any alliance with them. Our main concern is to strengthen the UNPA.



SAURABH SINGH



The Samajwadi Party is now having cocktail with the Congress and the CBI is the bartender.

EPILOGUE: Land scam allegations in Uttar Pradesh take a political turn and rope in the CBI as well.